The Praise Called the Empowerment of the Buddha

Śuddhābhiṣekanāmastotra · Toh 1161 · Derge Tengyur
སངས་རྒྱས་དབང་བསྐུར་བ་ཞེས་བྱ་བའི་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise Called the Empowerment of the Buddha, whose Sanskrit title is given as Śuddhābhiṣekanāmastotra and which is known in Tibetan as Sangyé Wangkurwa Zhejawé Töpa, is a short hymn in verse celebrating the birth of the Buddha Śākyamuni. It tells how the Sage, having perfected the perfections over three countless eons, came down from the heavens to be conceived in the womb of Queen Māyādevī, wife of King Śuddhodana, and was born in the grove of Lumbinī, where he took seven steps and proclaimed that this was his final birth. The gods then bathed and consecrated the newborn with divine water poured from golden vases, the royal lustration that the text calls his empowerment, while wonders spread through the whole world and every being was freed for a moment from sickness, harm, and suffering. The praise closes by promising long life, health, prosperity, victory, and fame to people of faith who listen to it and proclaim the qualities of the Buddha. It is Toh 1161 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the collection of praises (stotra), and its colophon credits the translation to the great Tibetan translator Rinchen Zangpo.

In Sanskrit: śuddha abhiṣeka nāma stotraḥ
In Tibetan: The Praise Called the Empowerment of the Buddha

Homage to the Omniscient One.

Then the Sage who, over three countless eons,
Had brought the perfections to completion,
The Teacher of the gods,
Came down from the heavens into the world of humans.

Of Śuddhodana, lord of the earth,
The moon of the solar lineage,
And of the chief queen, Māyādevī,
He was conceived within the womb.

There, dwelling in a jeweled pavilion,
While the foremost of the gods offered praise,
To them, with exalted speech,
He taught the sublime Dharma.

The gods, with palms joined,
Gazed on him there at the three times of day,
And he was like a stainless string of pearls
Resting within a vessel of beryl.

Her form bestowing the supreme nectar,
The queen who was worthy of him grew beautiful,
Like the moon at its most radiant,
Or like the pearly ocean of milk.

She brought relief to creatures as well,
And fulfilled the aims they hoped for in their minds;
She gave to those who wished,
And brought every desire to fulfillment.

To the pleasure grove of Lumbinī
Went the foremost lady of the world,
And there she stayed together with the lord of the earth,
The royal retinue, and the royal priest.

There she took hold of a branch
Of an aśoka tree, abiding in her vows.
In the sky the divine maidens
Were like the moon and the hosts of stars.

When the hour came under the star Puṣya,
From the side of her ribs her son,
He who knows what brings benefit to beings,
Came forth like the rising sun.

Perfectly complete with the supreme major marks,
The Lord's own body shed a light
Like gold from the Jambū River,
And all the directions were brightly illumined.

With a movement of his brows he turned away
Śakra (Indra), who wore the guise of a nurse,
And when he took seven steps upon the ground,
It became adorned with treasures and with lotuses.

"This is my final birth;
There is no further rebirth."
Having proclaimed this in melodious speech,

He gazed out in every direction.

From the jeweled vases of the sun and moon,
Two streams of water, warm and cool,
Came down out of the stainless sky
And fell upon his head.

The Sugata (the Buddha), guru of beings,
On a lofty lion throne
Spread with jewels of every kind,
Joyfully took his seat there.

Taking divine water from the rivers
And bathing fords of Śakra's abode,
With vases made of gold
The gods bestowed on him the empowerment.

With divine garments and with garlands,
And with many hosts intent on praise
Who had gathered there,
The divine grove was filled.

The sound of drums and the clamor
Pervaded the whole expanse of the sky,
And from the sky a rain of flowers
Fell without ceasing.

Strewn like a carpet with mandāra flowers,
The place became like the realm of the Pure Abodes,
And powdered camphor and sandalwood
Were scattered over the Protector of the World.

The mountains, together with the oceans,
Swayed like the garments of a dancer,
And the earth, which holds all manner of riches,
Shook in six ways.

The bees hummed aloud,
And the trees of every season
Bowed down of their own accord,
And the flowers bloomed in abundance.

The elder ministers and the royal priest
Recited auspicious blessings,
And those of earth and sky, and the siddhas,
Made merry together with the kiṃnaras.

The gods who dwell in the forests,
Gods, siddhas, vidyādharas, and humans,
And the women of the inner palace too
Danced for very joy.

The blind gained sight, the deaf their hearing,
The mute a clear voice,
And the sick release from their sickness:
All this they attained in that very instant.

Wild beasts, birds, scorpions, and snakes,
All the sentient beings
That wished to harm one another,
At that time became free of strife and harm.

At that time no suffering at all
And no wrongdoing arose;
These beings were free of disease
And happy, and the harvests flourished.

At that time, everywhere before them,
Treasures came forth;
At that time the three realms of existence
Flourished in joy and happiness.

The meritorious empowerment of the Victor:
For those who, with minds endowed with merit,
Listen to it,
Every excellence lies in the palm of their hand.

Long life, health, and power,
The quelling of foes, prosperity, victory, and fame:
These will be attained by the person of faith
Who proclaims the qualities of the perfect Buddha.

The Praise Called the Empowerment of the Buddha is complete.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the great translator Rinchen Zangpo.

Translator's Notes

• "Empowerment" renders abhiṣeka; here it is the consecrating bath the gods give the newborn bodhisattva with water from golden vases, a royal lustration that gives the praise its name, not a tantric initiation.
In the stanza on Śakra the Tibetan does not name who makes the gesture of the brows; it is read as the newborn turning aside Śakra, who appeared in the guise of a nurse, before taking his seven steps unaided.
Three apparent copyists' slips are translated in their evident sense: "went" for a syllable that gives no sense where the queen goes to Lumbinī, "bees" for a word that gives no sense in the line on humming, and "scorpions and snakes" for a misspelled compound.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.